

Existence of God: the cosmological argument



Thomas Aquinas used his ideas of essence and existence to refute Anselm's ontological argument for the existence of God (see [Existence of God: the ontological argument](#)). Instead, he proposed a stronger argument, known as the cosmological argument, derived from Aristotle's notion of causes (see [The four causes and the nature of being](#)). In brief, he argued that something must have caused the universe to exist, a First Cause, and this is what we call God. As explanation, Aquinas says that although the universe obviously exists, it is conceivable that in other circumstances it might not exist; its existence is therefore contingent on a cause. This has to be something that

cannot conceivably *not exist*, and is not contingent on anything else – an uncaused cause. This, Aquinas says, we understand to be God. The similarity of the cosmological argument to the scientific Big Bang theory is striking, and both involve the philosophically problematic acceptance of a first, uncaused, cause. However, refuting it by denying the possibility of an uncaused cause involves the equally difficult problem of infinite regress (see [Infinite regress](#)).